Gotthilf Heinrich von Schubert — *Ansichten von der Nachtseite der Naturwissenschaft* (1808)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Gotthilf Heinrich von Schubert (1780–1860), who turned his lectures at Dresden in 1808 toward what natural science could not yet describe in the open: dreams, the harmony of man with nature, animal magnetism and clairvoyance. Scholarship calls the book his influential study, a report of a realm of nature not visible simply from or to our perspective. Yet his influence scattered unevenly. The Falun miner case, on two pages of the book, lived on in later writing, while no translation of the whole book was found after research, and English readers were left with a single short excerpt made for one essay. This edition is dedicated to Schubert whole, in his own order and his own words.

The story

Every science has a day side, the part that can be measured in the open. Gotthilf Heinrich von Schubert (1780–1860) set out, in lectures published at Dresden in 1808, to look at the night side.

His book, *Ansichten von der Nachtseite der Naturwissenschaft*, may be rendered in English as *Views from the Night Side of Natural Science*. The lectures treat dreams, the harmony of man with nature, planetary orbits, animal magnetism, and clairvoyance — subjects that sit at the edge of what natural science, in his time,

could describe. Scholarship calls it Schubert's "influential study," reporting "a realm of nature that was not visible simply from or to our perspective." In the words of this dossier, it is a study of the unconscious before the term existed.

Among its cases is one that has lived on in later writing: the famous Falun miner case, at pages 215–216. A single episode, in a book of lectures, became the part of Schubert that later writers returned to, while the book as a whole stayed untranslated.

That contrast is the reason for this dossier. Schubert's influence is acknowledged, his most famous passage is retold, and yet the English reader who wants the whole argument, in Schubert's own order and his own words, has not been given the book to read.

The work and what survives

The survival of this work is unusually good. The Deutsches Textarchiv provides a digitisation and a full text, in TEI format, of the Dresden 1808 edition: 485 scans, about 687,166 characters, and about 94,682 tokens. An Internet Archive scan identifier, `ansichtenvonder01schugoog`, is recorded in the author bibliography.

The practical importance of that base cannot be overstated. The original is printed in Fraktur, the black-letter type that makes older German books hard for both readers and machines to work from. Here, that problem is already solved. There is a checked transcription to translate from, with the scans alongside it for verification.

The original dates from 1808, and Schubert lived from 1780 to 1860, so the work is in the public domain.

Its English fortunes

No English translation found after research.

The only English rendering located is a single short excerpt — page 215 and following, the Falun bride passage — translated ad hoc, for the occasion, for a blog essay. One passage, Englished for one essay, is not a translation of the book. It is evidence of the gap, because it shows a writer having to make the passage in English himself in order to use it.

What completing it would take

Completing this work means one book-length translation, of about 95,000 German words. That is a substantial undertaking, but it is uniquely tractable among this kind of work because of the Deutsches Textarchiv base: a checked transcription, full scans, and no need to solve the Fraktur problem before translation can begin.

The thematic fit is exact. Dreams, magnetism, clairvoyance, and the night side itself are the book's own subjects, from its title onward. A completed English edition would let readers judge Schubert whole — the influential study as a study, not only the famous two pages at Falun — and it would do so from the best text base recorded for any work in this part of the collection.

Sources

- https://www.deutschestextarchiv.de/book/show/schubert_naturwissenschaft_1808 (DTA text + scans)
- https://www.euromanticism.org/falun-copper-mine-falu-gruva/ (the Falun case)
- http://figures-of-speech.com/2017/12/lucy.htm (the lone excerpt)
- https://de.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gotthilf_Heinrich_von_Schubert (IA identifier)